In representative democracy like ours, elections are extremely important. Voting in elections are the best way to make your 'voice' heard.

2.1.2 Introduction of the NOTA Option

If the people in a democratic country are not willing to elect any candidate, they can vote for the option called NOTA (None Of The Above). Rule 49-O in the Conduct of Elections Rules, 1961, of India describes this procedure.



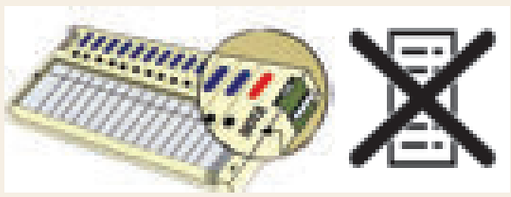
Voters Verified Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT)



Voters Verified Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) is the way forward to enhance credibility and transparency of the election process. This system was first introduced in the 2014 General Election.



NOTA was first introduced in the General Elections held in 2014. India is the 14th country in the world to introduce NOTA.



Symbol used with NOTA option on electronic voting machines in India

2.1.3 Types of Elections in India

Elections are classified into two types: direct and indirect elections.

Direct Elections

People directly vote for the candidates in the fray and elect their representatives. The following are examples of direct elections in which people over the age of 18 years participate in the electoral process by casting their votes.

(i) Lok Sabha elections, in which the Members of Parliament are elected.

(ii) Elections to the state Legislative Assemblies, in which the Members of Legislative Assemblies are elected.

(iii) Elections to the local governing bodies, **i.e** such as village panchayat, town panchayat, municipalities, municipalcorporation are conducted by the state election commission.

Merits

(i) As the voters elect their representatives directly, direct elections are considered to be a more democratic method of election.

(ii) It educates people regarding the government activities and helps in choosing the appropriate candidates. Also, it encourages people to play an active role in politics.

(iii) It empowers people and makes the rulers accountable for their actions.

Demerits

(i) Direct elections are very exspensive.

(ii) Illiterate voters sometimes get misguided by false propaganda. Campaigning based on caste, religion and various other sectarian considerations pose serious challenges.

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